of the Vedic Science Centre in Varanasi. It had earlier worked on the Kashi Vishwanath corridor and initiated work on the Kailash Mansarovar Bhawan. The CM has also asked department officials to come up with new ideas.

Speaking to INDIA TODAY, Mukesh Meshram, the additional chief secretary of the department, says, "We are focusing on the projects given to us. Our first priority is the development work in Ayodhya as we are the budgeting agency for the three paths that will be developed there."

A department that you were once banished to if you had fallen out of favour—as Navneet Sehgal, a key officer of the Mayawati government, was in 2012 when Akhilesh Yadav became chief minister—has now become one where every official aspires to be posted to. Religious tourism is a major focus of CM Adityanath, who is also the mahant of the Gorakhnath Peeth. Meshram, incidentally, also handles tourism in addition to the *dharmarth karya* responsibilities.

In December 2020, the UP government announced the setting up of a directorate of religious affairs for the "smooth functioning of religious activities" in the state. The directorate's headquarters were in a building provided by the Kashi Vishwanath Distinguished Area Development Council in Varanasi district, while another sub-office will be situated in Kailash Mansarovar Bhawan. Varanasi divisional commissioner Deepak Agrawal has been appointed as its first director. With the Ram temple in Ayodhya set to be completed by December 2023, expect religious affairs to continue to be government policy and electoral plank for the BJP governments in UP and at the Centre till the 2024 election. ■

NEW CDS

THE GENERAL FOR THE JOB

By Pradip R. Sagar

The Indian armed forces have finally got their top commander. On Friday, September 30, General Anil Chauhan took over as the Chief of Defence Staff (CDS), in a low-key event held away from the media glare. A man of few words, Gen. Chauhan, 61, has let his military record speak for him so far. As the director general of military operations (DGMO), he oversaw the Balakot airstrike on a terror camp deep inside Pakistan territory in 2019, and was in the thick of things, as the Eastern army commander, when China started flexing its muscles along India's eastern frontiers in 2020.

The top defence post—created to improve the coordination and overall integration of the combat capabilities of the Indian armed forces—had been vacant for almost 10 months after India's first CDS, Gen. Bipin Rawat, died in a chopper crash in December 2021. With the appointment of Gen. Chauhan as the country's second CDS, it is for the first time in the history of the Indian military that a retired three-star general has returned to active service as a four-star general.

In June, when the Centre amended the service rules, making retired officers eligible to be appointed as CDS, military circles were abuzz with Gen. Chauhan's name as a possible contender. Even as he had retired in May 2021, Gen. Chauhan had been working closely with National Security Advisor Ajit Doval as a military advisor in the National Security Council Secretariat, which gave him a holistic view of the government's short- and long-term defence plans.



INDIA PICTURE

WEST BENGAL

THE V-C FIASCO

By Romita Datta

The abrasive influence of politics and the alleged violation of law have ensured that the 165-year-old Calcutta University is without a vice-chancellor for the past fortnight. The division bench of the Calcutta High Court under Chief Justice Prakash Shrivastava has struck down the reappointment of V-C Sonali Chakrabarty Banerjee for a second term by the state government, saying it violated the Calcutta University Act, 1979 and UGC Regulations, 2015.

Acting on a PIL, the high court ruled on September 13 that contrary to legal requirement, Chakrabarty-Banerjee's reappointment on August 27, 2021, was done through a special secretary of the higher education department, when the power of appointment/ reappointment according to both laws rests solely with the chancellor—the governor of the state in this case. The state government